If certain small sounds provoke instant, disproportionate rage or panic in you, you are not being difficult and you are far from alone. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Misophonia is a strongly reduced tolerance to specific sounds — most often chewing, breathing, sniffing, tapping, pen-clicking. Triggers provoke immediate anger, panic or disgust that the person knows is out of proportion and cannot stop. Brain imaging suggests real differences in how these sounds are processed. It affects a substantial minority of people and commonly starts in childhood.

What it can feel like from the inside

- A sound arriving like an assault, with rage or panic before any thought.
- Being unable to hear anything else once you've noticed it.
- Feeling ridiculous and ashamed of a reaction you can't control.
- Avoiding meals with people you love.
- Being told you're overreacting by everyone, for years.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"Everyone hates chewing sounds."	Mild annoyance isn't the same as a full fight-or-flight response.
"You're being rude."	The reaction arrives before any decision. Leaving the room is the polite version.
"Just ignore it."	The difficulty disengaging attention is the core of the condition.
"It's not a real thing."	It's increasingly well evidenced, including on brain imaging.
"They'll grow out of it."	It usually starts in childhood and often persists. Management helps; growing out doesn't.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Exceptional attention to sound and detail.

Often musical, or acutely attuned to tone and rhythm.

Strong self-awareness about their own reactions.

Considerable self-control — most people mask this for years.

Empathy for anyone with an invisible difficulty.

What actually helps

- ☐ Don't take the reaction personally
- ☐ Eat with the telly or music on
- ☐ Give them a seat furthest from noise
- ☐ Let them wear headphones at meals
- ☐ Don't tap, click or crunch deliberately
- ☐ Believe them the first time

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“Tell me if I'm doing it.”

“Shall I put some music on?”

“Sit wherever's easiest.”

LESS HELPFUL

“It's only eating.”

“You're so sensitive.”

doing it on purpose to tease

The rage isn't aimed at you. It arrives before anyone gets a say in it.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk